

The Washington Post

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Democracy Dies in Darkness

THURSDAY, MARCH 27, 2025 • \$4

Md.'s lax oversight had a hand in disaster

6 deaths may have been preventable, records tied to bridge collapse show

BY KATIE METTLER AND TEO ARMUS

Damon Davis was walking to his car, parked on the south end of the Francis Scott Key Bridge in Baltimore, when he felt the road-way shake.

It was the middle of the night one year ago Wednesday and Davis, a construction inspector overseeing a seven-man road repair crew, could see nothing but darkness across the Patapsco River. But he heard a thunderous crunch, he would later tell investigators, so he ran.

Behind him, the sprawling bridge was falling — plunging his car and the work crew 185 feet into the icy waters below.

Davis reached for his cellphone, he said, the one that Maryland officials were supposed to call in case of an emergency. But it never rang. Not at 1:27 a.m., about two minutes before the bridge collapsed, when a 984-foot cargo ship called the Dali issued a mayday call that the vessel had lost power. Not moments later, when Maryland Transportation Authority officials told police to stop all traffic crossing the span as the Dali drifted toward one of the bridge's support pillars. Not when those officers realized there was a work crew still on the bridge.

One year later, it's still not clear why the men working on the Key Bridge that night were never warned — and what, if anything, has changed to prevent a tragedy like this one, which killed six of the workers and left the two survivors reeling.

Amid a flurry of ongoing lawsuits, Gov. Wes Moore (D) and Maryland Transportation Authority officials have said the Key Bridge collapse was the “sole fault” of the owner and the operator of the Dali cargo ship, Grace Ocean Private Limited and Synergy Marine Group.

But a Washington Post review of thousands of pages of documents related to the Key Bridge tragedy found that lenient safety

SEE KEY BRIDGE ON A20

Families, officials mourn: A year later, lost lives remembered. B1

Peak joy



MATT MCCLAIN/THE WASHINGTON POST

Toan Le embraces his fiancée, Hien Pham, on Wednesday along the Tidal Basin beneath some of Washington's famed cherry blossoms, which are racing toward peak bloom this week.

Leak affirms Vance's role as foreign intervention skeptic

BY NATALIE ALLISON AND MICHAEL BIRNBAUM

In a chain of private messages among President Donald Trump's top national security officials, Vice President JD Vance appeared, even behind the scenes, to be serving as one of the administration's most consistent skeptics of foreign intervention — a key component of Trump's “America First” platform.

The dynamic has been on display in rancorous encounters in Europe, in an angry Oval Office meeting with Ukraine's leader, in blistering assessments of U.S. allies during Vance's public appearances — and now inside a private group chat about plans to bomb Yemen's Houthi militants.

All of it has international policymakers scrambling to adjust their strategies.

Diplomats, ministers and other senior leaders abroad are zeroing in on Vance as one of their biggest challenges as they confront how to handle Trump's second term. They say Vance appears to be the most committed in Trump's inner circle to scaling back international commitments.

That ideological viewpoint contrasts with what these leaders say is Trump's more transactional nature. The president, they felt, could be swayed with flattery, U.S. investments and other deals that he could present as easy victories. Vance is a trickier counterpart and more skeptical of them in ways they can do little to address.

Mindful that the vice president could be Trump's successor in 2029, some officials say Vance's policies could be emblematic of a

SEE VANCE ON A6

Atlantic publishes transcript of Trump team's Signal chat

BY ALEX HORTON, MISSY RYAN AND MATT VISER

The Atlantic on Wednesday published a transcript of top Trump administration officials' group chat discussing an imminent U.S. attack on Houthi militants in Yemen, revealing a fuller accounting of the sensitive information they exchanged while the magazine's editor, Jeffrey Goldberg, observed their conversation as it occurred over an unclassified, commercially available messaging platform.

The newly disclosed material adds to a mounting controversy about the decision by the nation's most senior national security officials — including President Donald Trump's national security ad-

viser, his secretaries of defense and state, the director of national intelligence, the CIA director, and Vice President JD Vance — to discuss sensitive military planning using the messaging app Signal, which is encrypted but not permitted by government rules for discussions of classified information. Further roiling the debate is their total lack of awareness that the group accidentally included a journalist.

Former officials and lawmakers said the negligent tradecraft almost certainly violated the government's strict rules for handling of classified information and may have risked exposing operational plans to adversaries as American pilots prepared to take flight.

The episode has infuriated

SEE LEAK ON A7

The Fix: Trump team's latest leak theory doesn't help its case. A6

House hearing: Gabbard, Ratcliffe face new questions about leak. A7

Justices uphold Biden-era regulations on ghost guns

BY JUSTIN JOUVENAL

The Supreme Court on Wednesday upheld the Biden administration's regulation of ghost guns, the largely untraceable firearms that have been used in a growing number of crimes over the past decade, prompting concern and scrutiny from law enforcement agencies.

In a 7-2 decision written by Justice Neil M. Gorsuch, the justices allowed 2022 rules from the Bureau of Alcohol, Tobacco, Firearms and Explosives that require serial numbers, sales receipts and background checks for the weapons, which are typically purchased online as kits that let the buyer complete assembly at home. Justices Samuel A. Alito Jr. and Clarence Thomas dissented in separate opinions.

The ruling — supported by justices on both sides of the Supreme Court's partisan divide — could be

considered a departure for the court's conservative majority, which has been skeptical of gun regulation in recent terms. The justices issued a landmark decision in 2022 that made it easier to challenge restrictions on firearms.

In the ghost gun case, the justices ruled that the weapons, which are sold partially assembled, count as firearms under the 1968 Gun Control Act. That means they can be regulated in the same way as other commercially available guns. The case, which was one of the most significant of the current term, did not implicate the right to bear arms that is enshrined in the Second Amendment.

Gorsuch noted in his opinion that some ghost gun kits may be so incomplete or cumbersome to assemble that they would not count as firearms under the Gun Control

SEE GHOST GUNS ON A4



ALLISON JOYCE/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

In Southeast, a fierce fire season threatens

A fire crew in Flat Rock, North Carolina, oversees a controlled burn last week. Felled timber from Hurricane Helene could provide a decade of fuel for blazes, foresters say. Story, A9

IN THE NEWS

Climate clawback? Biden officials rushed to set up billions to promote clean energy. Now, Trump officials seek to rescind most of it. A16

Testing the limits President Donald Trump's actions have pushed the country into fraught territory, experts say, but they are divided on whether guardrails have been breached. A2

THE NATION **Social Security** backed off plans to eliminate the by-phone option for disabled Americans. A3 **An appeals court** upheld a temporary block on Alien Enemies Act deportations. A4

THE WORLD **Recent sectarian** violence in Syria was pre-saged by an attack on Alawites in January. A10 **The Vances'** shifting Greenland plans will take them to a U.S. base, not the capital. A13

THE CLIMATE **As the cannabis** industry grows, some seek to reduce its massive use of energy, which exceeds even bitcoin mining. A8

THE ECONOMY **Dollar Tree** will sell the ailing Family Dollar discount chain for \$1 billion, a fraction of its acquisition cost. A14

THE REGION **A bill** that would nullify the District's “sanctuary city” law has been advanced by House Republicans. B1 **Kermit the Frog**, created by University of Maryland alumnus Jim Henson, will deliver the spring commencement in College Park. B1

STYLE **“Everything Is Tuberculosis”** author John Green, who is known for his optimism, is fighting despair as funding for medical programs disappears. C1

LOCAL LIVING **Don't use** newspaper to clean windows, and more myths debunked.

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